

Heat wave in L.A. may be a record

Officials warn of coming extreme highs as other parts of U.S. face extreme cold.

By CLARA HARTER

Extreme weather alerts blanketed the nation Friday as Southern California endured temperatures 15 to 25 degrees above normal and braced for even hotter conditions next week.

Nearly every part of the United States was either experiencing or preparing for wild weather this weekend, with flooding forecast for Hawaii, 100-degree-plus days predicted for the Southwest and a polar vortex expected to deliver Arctic chilling throughout the Midwest and East.

"All of the country, even if you're not necessarily seeing extremes, are going to see generally changing from cold to warm, or warm to cold to warm," said meteorologist Marc Chenard of the National Weather Service's Weather Prediction Center in Maryland.

Although Southern California will see a slight dip in temperatures on Saturday, officials warned that another round of even more extreme heat would arrive next week thanks to a high-pressure heat dome parked over much of the Southwest. That will bring additional heat advisories and more record-breaking temperatures, according to the weather service.

Elsewhere in the Southwest, meteorologists predict that Phoenix will hit 98 degrees on Tuesday, followed by 103, 105 and two days of 107 degrees.

In 137 years of record-keeping, Phoenix has never hit 100 before March 26, according to the weather service, which warned: "Since we are not acclimated to this level of heat this early in the year, it will be more impactful than usual."

Around the same time heat starts baking the Southwest, the polar vortex — a system that usually keeps frigid air penned up near the North Pole — is forecast to send its chill deep into the Midwest and East, even bordering some of the Southeast, according to Ryan Maue, former National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration chief scientist.

Temperatures in Minneapolis will hover around zero for a low, and Chicago will be in the single digits Tuesday. The following day will bring "temperatures in the teens and 20s in the Northeast and 20s in the Mid-Atlantic," Maue said. Even Atlanta could drop to the 20s. Two storm systems in a row — one Friday, then another Sunday into Monday — will chug along the country's northern tier and Great Lakes and could dump 3 to 4 feet of snow in places, Maue said.

In Los Angeles and the rest of Southern California, the extended sweltering temperatures could be "one of the top heat wave events for the month of March—ever," the NWS said in its [See Heat wave, A7]



GENARO MOLINA Los Angeles Times



Washington State Department of Transportation

AT TOP, surfers in morning mist Friday after catching waves in Santa Monica. It was a scorcher in L.A. area. Above, heavy snow on a highway in Washington state.

Reeling Cuba says it has begun talks with U.S.

By PATRICK J. McDONNELL, KATE LINTHICUM AND ANA CEBALLOS

MEXICO CITY — Cuba, reeling from an oil shortage, has begun direct talks with the United States in an effort to solve "bilateral differences" between the two countries, Cuban President Miguel Díaz-Canel said Friday.

The comments, broadcast nationwide in Cuba, are the first confirmation of negotiations between the Trump administration and Havana. The U.S. and Cuba have been fierce adversaries for nearly 70 years, since Fidel Castro's revolution toppled the U.S.-backed dictator Fulgencio Batista.

The Trump administration has been ratcheting up pressure on Cuba's communist government for months, choking off oil supplies to the island

and threatening military action against its leaders.

"It may be a friendly takeover, it may not be a friendly takeover," Trump warned this week.

Ricardo Torres, an economist and research fellow at American University in Washington, said Trump's threats and Cuba's deepening energy crisis had forced Havana to the negotiating table.

"The country is barely surviving," Torres said, citing rolling blackouts and severe shortages of food, medicine and gasoline. "Cuba doesn't have a choice. It has to talk."

Still, what exactly the Trump administration hopes to achieve in the negotiations is not clear. [See Cuba, A4]



YAMIL LAGE AFP via Getty Images

A WOMAN wearing an American flag T-shirt sells cookies in Havana.

EPA may lift carcinogen limits

By HAYLEY SMITH

The Trump administration on Friday moved to roll back Biden-era limits on emissions of ethylene oxide, a cancer-causing chemical often used in the steriliza-

tion of medical devices.

The Environmental Protection Agency said repealing the rules, which fall under the National Emission Standards for Hazardous Air Pollutants, would "safeguard the supply of essential medical equipment"

— saving approximately \$630 million for companies over 20 years. California is home to about a dozen such facilities.

The government said the emissions are an inevitable part of protecting people [See EPA, A9]

6 U.S. troops die in crash; 2,500 sent to Mideast

A refueling jet is lost in Iraq, raising war toll to 13. Key Iran island is bombed, Trump says.

By GAVIN J. QUINTON

WASHINGTON — Six American airmen deployed to operations against Iran were killed after their refueling aircraft crashed in western Iraq, U.S. Central Command said Friday, bringing the U.S. death toll in the war to 13, as Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth ordered a deployment of Marines to the region ahead of the heaviest day of strikes yet.

The crash involved two aircraft in "friendly airspace," the Pentagon said, adding that the other plane landed safely. The downed KC-135 refueling tanker is the fourth U.S. aircraft to crash during the war against Iran.

"American heroes, all of them," Hegseth said at the Pentagon on Friday. "We will greet those heroes at Dover and their sacrifice will only recommit us to the resolve of this mission."

Central Command said the incident is under investigation but was "not due to hostile or friendly fire."

The Defense secretary said Friday would see Iran hammered with the heaviest round of airstrikes yet seen in the two-week U.S.-Israeli operation that has razed buildings, complexes and factory lines all across Iran, killing at least 1,348 civilians, according to Iranian officials.

"No quarter, no mercy for our enemies," Hegseth said.

As Hegseth delivered his remarks, the USS Tripoli amphibious assault ship and some 2,500 Marines prepared to embark on a two-week journey from Japan to the Middle East on his orders, the Associated Press and other outlets reported.

The move will add warships, troops and fighter jets to support Marines already in the Middle East.

The deployment comes amid media speculation that the U.S. may be gathering troops for a ground invasion of the Iranian-held Kharg Island, the country's main oil export outlet. President Trump told Fox News that the island is "not high on my list," of war priorities, but "I can change my mind in seconds."

Later Friday, Trump posted on his social media site that U.S. forces at his direction had carried out bombing raids that "totally obliterated every MILITARY target" on Kharg Island, while leaving its oil infrastructure intact. But he threatened to "immediately reconsider this decision" if Iran "or anyone else" interfered with ships passing through the Strait of Hormuz.

And although Hegseth insisted that fighting will cease when the U.S. destroys Iran's naval, missile and nuclear weapons capabilities, the president's public statements continue to sow doubt that the White House and Pentagon are aligned on the objectives of the mission.

Asked Friday by Fox News when the war might [See Iran, A4]

Amid Iran war concerns, Oscars get tighter security

A one-mile police buffer around Dolby Theatre is among added safeguards.

By RICHARD WINTON AND HANNAH FRY

It's been more than two decades since the Oscars were celebrated as the United States was launching a war in the Middle East.

In 2003, the Academy Awards ceremony at the Dolby Theatre occurred just days after U.S. troops invaded Iraq, elevating security concerns surrounding Hollywood's biggest night so much that they tightened security like never before.

This time around — with concerns heightened not only because of a war with Iran, but also a recent shooting at a university in Virginia and an attack on a synagogue in Michigan — security is going to be even more

ironclad, authorities said. The dialed-up security, law enforcement and Oscars officials emphasize, is precautionary and there are no known credible threats to the event.

Authorities are setting up a one-mile security perimeter around the Dolby Theatre for the celebration. Federal and local agencies working with the Joint Terrorism Task Force are monitoring social media and gathering intelligence to prevent any security risks. And the Los Angeles Police Department's SWAT team, bomb squad and snipers will be in the area, law enforcement sources told The Times.

LAPD Capt. Mike Bland said the department in recent years created a specialized group to handle major events and that it now uses many more personnel for the Oscars.

"Security is heightened more than years past not [See Oscars, A7]

Push for LAPD oversight heads toward ballot

By LIBOR JANY

A series of proposed changes to the city's charter — essentially its constitution — could give elected leaders in Los Angeles more oversight of the Police Department and enable the chief to fire problematic officers, reforms long sought by advocates that are likely to

again face fierce opposition.

Among the recommendations approved last week by the city's Charter Reform Commission was a proposal that would require any LAPD accountability-related motion or ordinance passed by the City Council to automatically become law if not acted on by the Police Commission within 60 days.

Once the language is fi-

nalized, the proposals must clear the City Council and its committees before they can be put to voters on November's ballot.

Another proposal would give city leaders the ability to override decisions by the Police Commission, a board appointed by the mayor that sets LAPD policies, oversees its budget and serves as a civilian watchdog.

With the police chief taking criticism for a recent rise in shootings by officers, several proposals sought to strengthen accountability for the use of deadly force. One recommendation could require the LAPD to purchase "no less than" \$1 million of liability insurance for its roughly 8,700 officers. The insurance would be used to [See LAPD, A9]

Judge quashes subpoenas to Fed

Investigation into Powell about a building renovation has delayed Senate consideration of his successor. **NATION, A5**

Hegseth eager for CNN change

Comments about David Ellison taking over the news channel raise fears. **BUSINESS, A10**

Weather
Partly sunny; warm.
L.A. Basin: 83/56. **B8**

States sue over demand for data

Officials challenge U.S. policy requiring proof that race isn't illegally a factor in admissions. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

James adapts his game for Lakers

He sacrifices offense to help team climb standings in West. **SPORTS, B12**

